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General Knowledge
Modern History

STUDY NOTES

Committees & Commissions

Committees and Commissions

Introduction

- The evolution of modern India is marked by the establishment of several committees and commissions, which played a vital role in transforming the country's socio-political and economic landscape.
- These bodies were instituted during both the colonial era and the early years of Indian independence.
- They addressed pressing issues related to **governance, education, labor, agriculture, industry, and social welfare.**
- Their recommendations significantly influenced policy-making, laying the foundation for modern **Indian institutions** and administrative systems.

Background and Importance of Committees and Commissions

Colonial Period:

- During British rule, the **establishment** of committees and commissions was driven by the colonial administration's need to control, reform, and extract resources efficiently.

- These bodies were often aimed at addressing specific challenges, such as improving governance, revenue systems, and education policies.
- However, their recommendations were often implemented with colonial interests in mind, leading to mixed outcomes for Indians.

Post-Independence Period:

- After gaining independence in 1947, the Indian government used commissions as tools to address the socio-economic disparities inherited from colonial rule.
- These bodies were essential for nation-building, focusing on critical areas like **education**, **administrative** reform, **industrial** growth, and **social justice**.

Key Committees and Commissions

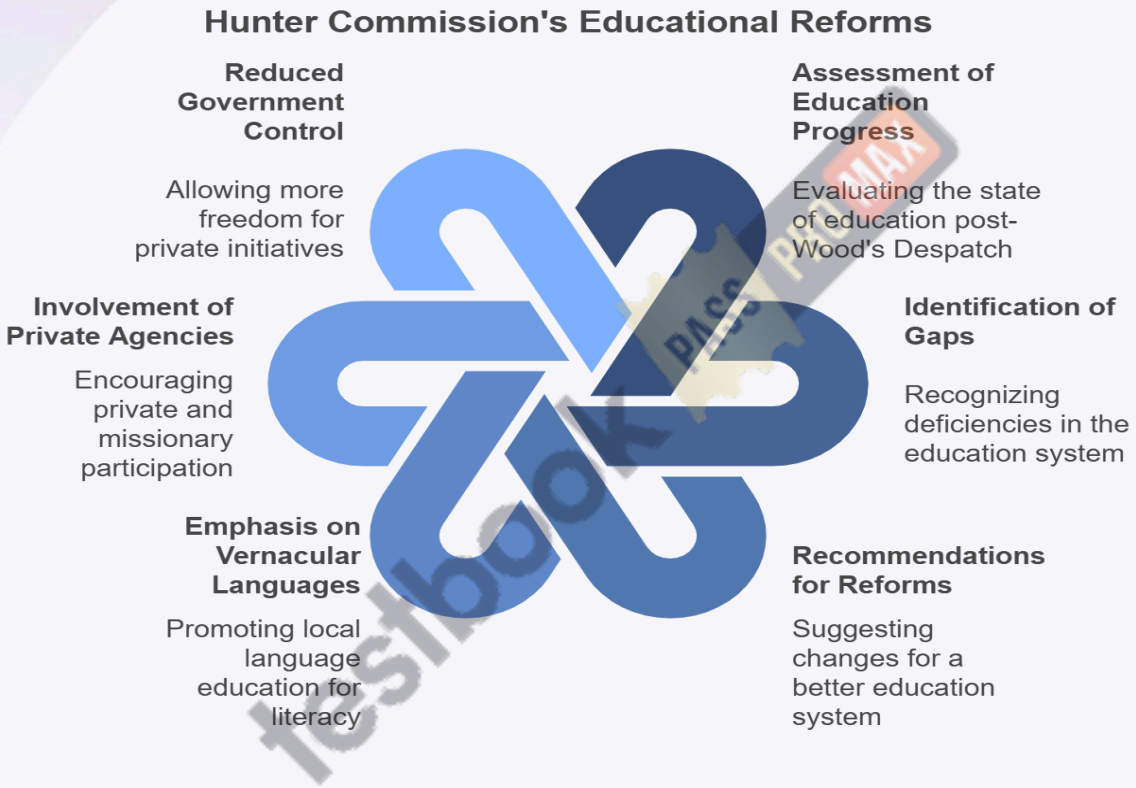
Name of the Committee/Commission	Year	Purpose/Objective	Key Recommendations
Hunter Education Commission	1882	To review the status of primary and secondary education in India.	Emphasized the role of private enterprises and vernacular education.
Indian Universities Commission	1902	To improve the quality of higher education in India.	Suggested reforms for better governance of universities.
Royal Commission on Public Services	1912	To assess the working of civil services in India.	Recommended improvements in training and recruitment of civil servants.
Montague-Chelmsford Reforms Committee	1918	To introduce constitutional reforms for greater Indian participation in governance.	Proposed dyarchy in provinces and limited self-governance.
Simon Commission	1927	To evaluate the working of the Government of India Act, 1919.	Recommended federal governance but faced strong opposition for excluding Indian members.
Hartog Committee	1929	To evaluate the education system, particularly the impact of previous education reforms.	Recommended reducing student dropouts and emphasized quality over quantity in education.
Sapru Committee	1944	To explore the possibility of constitutional reforms amidst the political deadlock.	Proposed safeguards for minorities and the formation of a constituent assembly.

Cripps Mission	**1942**	**To negotiate Indian cooperation in World War II and propose constitutional changes.**	**Suggested dominion status for India, which was rejected by Indian leaders.**
Cabinet Mission	**1946**	**To discuss and plan for the transfer of power from the British government to Indian leadership.**	**Proposed a federal structure and the formation of the Constituent Assembly.**
Dhar Commission	**1948**	**To assess the feasibility of reorganizing Indian states based on linguistic lines.**	**Opposed the immediate formation of states based on languages.**
StatesReorganization Commission	**1953**	**To reorganize states for better administrative efficiency and linguistic homogeneity.**	**Recommended the formation of states based on linguistic lines, leading to the States Reorganization Act.**
JVP Committee	**1948-49**	**To assess the demand for linguistic reorganization of Indian states.**	**Opposed immediate linguistic states. Emphasized national unity over linguistic division. Andhra's demand for a separate state was rejected.**
UGC Commission	**1948-49**	**To examine the state of university education and recommend reforms.**	**Autonomy for universities. Establishment of a central regulatory body. Emphasis on research and postgraduate programs. Promotion of regional languages alongside English.**

Hunter Education Commission (1882)

- The Hunter Commission was established to assess the progress of education in India after the implementation of **Wood's Despatch (1854)**.
- It aimed to identify gaps in the education system and recommend reforms to make **education** more accessible and **practical** for Indians.
- Emphasis on primary education in vernacular languages to ensure basic **literacy** and **education** for the masses.
- Greater involvement of private agencies and missionary organizations in the education sector to supplement government efforts.

- Reduced government control over education, allowing private initiatives to thrive.
- A shift from an exclusive focus on higher education to enhancing primary and secondary education would benefit the larger population.
- **Impact:**
    - This commission laid the foundation for an **education system** tailored to local needs and promoted mass education, although its implementation remained limited due to inadequate funding and lack of interest from the colonial government.



Indian Universities Commission (1902)

- This commission was established to reform and improve the quality of higher education in India, as universities were plagued by **inefficiency**, **lack of autonomy**, and **outdated curricula.**
- Stricter affiliation rules for colleges to maintain academic standards.
- Improved university administration by ensuring better governance structures and autonomy.
- Enhanced academic and examination standards to produce competent graduates.

Impact:

- It led to establishing the **Indian Universities Act, of 1904**, which aimed to regulate universities and improve their functioning.
- However, the act faced criticism for increasing government control over universities.

Royal Commission on Public Services (1912)

- This commission reviewed the structure and functioning of the civil services in British India and addressed the discriminatory practices against Indian officers.
- **Key Recommendations:**
    - Introduced merit-based recruitment for **civil services** to ensure a fair selection process.
    - Proposed localized training for Indian officers to make them more effective in understanding local needs.
    - Advocated equal pay for Indian and British civil servants to address disparities.
- **Impact:**
    - While it brought some reforms to recruitment and training, the implementation of equal pay and equal opportunities remained limited under colonial rule.

Montague-Chelmsford Reforms Committee (1918)

- Formulated to introduce constitutional reforms that allowed greater Indian participation in governance, this committee responded to growing nationalist demands.

- **Key Recommendations:**
  - Introduced **dyarchy** in provincial governments, dividing subjects into "reserved" (controlled by British officials) and "transferred" (handled by Indian ministers).
  - Allowed limited **self-governance** at the provincial level.
  - Expanded Indian representation in legislative councils.
- **Impact:**
  - These reforms led to the Government of **India Act, of 1919**, which marked a step towards **self-governance**. However, it fell short of nationalist aspirations for complete independence.

Simon Commission (1927)

- The commission was tasked with evaluating the workings of the **Government of India Act, of 1919**, and suggesting further constitutional reforms.
- **Key Recommendations:**
  - Proposed a federal structure with increased provincial autonomy.
  - Opposed immediate granting of **self-rule**, recommending gradual progress instead.
  - Suggested separate communal electorates for minorities.
- **Controversy:**
  - The commission excluded Indian members, leading to widespread protests and the famous slogan, "**Simon Go Back**." This opposition galvanized the Indian independence movement, furthering demands for complete self-rule.

Hartog Committee (1929)

- The **Hartog Committee** was set up to evaluate the education system after the Hunter Commission's recommendations and address the challenges of dropout rates and poor education quality.
- **Key Recommendations:**
  - Focused on vocational education to make education practical and employment-oriented.
  - Suggested measures to reduce student dropouts at the primary level.
  - Emphasized quality over quantity in education, discouraging expansion without improving standards.

- **Impact:**
  - Though its recommendations highlighted critical issues, implementation was slow and limited due to financial and administrative constraints.

Sapru Committee (1944)

- This committee aimed to resolve political deadlocks between Indian leaders and the British during the final years of colonial rule.
- **Key Recommendations:**
  - Proposed safeguards for minorities to ensure their rights and representation.
  - Advocated the formation of a **Constituent Assembly** to draft India's **Constitution**.
  - Highlighted the importance of national unity amidst growing communal tensions.
- **Impact:**
  - The committee's proposals influenced later constitutional developments and efforts to bridge communal divides.

Cripps Mission (1942)

- The Cripps Mission sought Indian cooperation in **World War II** by proposing constitutional changes and self-governance after the war.
- **Key Recommendations:**
  - Promised dominion status for India post-war.
  - Suggested the right for provinces to secede from the Indian Union.
  - Proposed setting up a **Constituent Assembly** to frame the Constitution.
- **Impact:**
  - Rejected by both Congress and the **Muslim League**, the mission failed to gain Indian support and highlighted the growing demand for complete independence.

Cabinet Mission (1946)

- The Cabinet Mission was formed to plan the transfer of power from the **British government** to Indian leadership.
- **Key Recommendations:**
  - Proposed a **three-tier** federation comprising **provinces**, **princely** states, and a central authority.

- Suggested a **Constituent Assembly** with proportional representation to draft the **Constitution**.
- Rejected the demand for a separate **Pakistan** but acknowledged communal concerns.

- **Impact:**
  - The mission's recommendations formed the basis for India's constitutional development, even as communal tensions escalated.

Dhar Commission (1948)

- This commission explored the reorganization of Indian states post-independence, considering linguistic and administrative factors.
- **Key Recommendations:**
  - Opposed the immediate formation of linguistic states due to **administrative challenges**.
  - **Advocated reorganization** based on **administrative** convenience rather than language.
- **Impact**:
  - Its recommendations were not fully accepted, but it initiated debates on linguistic reorganization, which gained momentum later.

States Reorganization Commission (1953)

- This commission was tasked with reorganizing Indian states to ensure administrative efficiency and linguistic harmony.
- **Key Recommendations:**
  - Recommended the creation of linguistic states like **Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, and Karnataka.**
  - Proposed the **States Reorganization Act of 1956**, which redrew India's political map.
- **Impact:**
  - The reorganization of states based on linguistic lines strengthened national unity while addressing regional aspirations.

JVP Committee (1948-49)

- The JVP Committee was formed to assess the demand for the reorganization of Indian states on a linguistic basis.
- It was named after its three members: **Jawaharlal Nehru**, **Vallabhbhai Patel**, and **Pattabhi Sitaramayya**.
- This committee was established in response to widespread demands for linguistic states, particularly from regions like **Andhra Pradesh**.
- **Key Recommendations:**
  - The committee opposed the immediate creation of linguistic states, arguing that it could lead to administrative inefficiency and undermine national unity.
  - They emphasized the need to prioritize national integration and economic development over linguistic division.
- **Gradual Approach:**
  - Recommended postponing linguistic reorganization until India achieved stability post-independence.
- **Rejection of Andhra's Demand:**
  - While acknowledging the sentiments of the Andhra region, the committee did not endorse the creation of Andhra Pradesh immediately, suggesting that language alone should not dictate state boundaries.
- **Impact:**
  - The **JVP** Committee delayed the linguistic reorganization of states temporarily. However, the demand for **Andhra Pradesh** gained momentum with the **Potti Sriramulu** hunger strike in **1952**, eventually leading to the creation of Andhra Pradesh in 1953.
  - Its recommendations underscored the tension between national unity and regional aspirations, setting the stage for the States Reorganization Commission (**1953).**

UGC Commission (1948-49)(Also known as the University Education Commission)

- This commission was appointed by the Government of India under the chairmanship of **Dr. S. Radhakrishnan** to examine the state of university education in India and recommend reforms.

- It laid the groundwork for the establishment of the **University Grants Commission (UGC)** in **1956**.
- **Key Recommendations:**
  - Highlighted the importance of education as a means of developing individual character, fostering democracy, and advancing economic and cultural progress.
- **Autonomy of Universities:**
  - **Emphasized** the need for universities to maintain autonomy from external influences, particularly political and bureaucratic interference.
  - **Quality and Standards:** Advocated for the improvement of academic standards and the introduction of specialized courses to meet societal needs.
  - Recommended research-focused postgraduate programs to enhance higher education.
- **Funding and Governance:**
  - Suggested that the government should allocate adequate funds to universities.
  - Proposed a central regulatory body to oversee higher education (leading to the establishment of UGC).
- **Language and Curriculum**:
  - Recommended teaching in regional languages while ensuring that English continued as a medium of higher education.
  - Proposed a well-rounded curriculum with a focus on liberal arts, sciences, and vocational training.
- **Impact:**
  - The recommendations led to the creation of the University Grants Commission (UGC) in 1956, tasked with overseeing university education in India.
  - Established a framework for improving higher education quality and promoting research.
  - The report remains a cornerstone in the history of Indian education, reflecting a vision of education that balances traditional values and modern needs.

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